only sent ballistic missiles to Cuba, but shorter-range weapons (including on submarines) without thinking through the implications or about the decisions he might have to confront.

## Damn Second Lieutenants

Several decades of research and revelation have shown the decision to cross the nuclear threshold would most likely have been taken by subordinate commanders (or even individual pilots). What would Kennedy or Khrushchev then have done? Perhaps Kennedy provides a clue with his handling of the loss of Major Anderson's U-2. Under Op-Plan 312, if a U-2 were shot down, US aircraft were to strike within two hours, at either the S-75 site responsible or at all the SAM bases. Sixteen F-100 Super Sabers were placed on 30-minute alert at Homestead Air Force base ready to respond. McGeorge Bundy later recalled, 'The tradition of arms demanded not only that Anderson's death be avenged, but also that the men who followed him be protected.'[94] Nevertheless, Kennedy paused retaliation to give diplomacy (what was looking like) a last chance. It was widely believed that the Joint Chiefs were angry at this decision, but as Martin Sherwin shows, they were not unduly exercised about further reconnaissance, as they assumed the attack on Cuba was about to commence.[95] The one chief who wanted military retaliation was Maxwell Taylor.

Kennedy and Khrushchev both worried about their ability to control events. Once nuclear weapons began to explode, at what point would they have felt they had lost control? Would they then have succumbed to the undoubted and undoubtedly enormous pressure to retaliate and/or escalate? There are intriguing vignettes of JFK's personal beliefs about nuclear war. One of his mistresses, Mimi Alford (who had a relationship with the President from June 1962 to November 1963), recounts that Kennedy confided to her: 'I'd rather my children be red than dead.'[96] The conversation took place in his bedroom on the evening of Friday 26 October, she recalls. Kenny O'Donnell, his long-time friend and political aide, is also quoted on Kennedy's private views: 'He could discuss the